

advantage that the Alcatel has is that a single name can be assigned 3 different numbers. This saves lots of space since many contacts have both mobile and land line numbers, and therefore managing and retrieving them becomes very easy.

SMS

SMS is used extensively to exchange pictures, jokes and important messages. Manufacturers are now selling mobiles in which the user can type a message as long as 460 characters. However, because of the GSM standard limitation, you will not be able to send or receive a single message with more than 160 characters. Newer handsets break long messages into units of 160 characters and send or receive them. All the 33xx phones from Nokia can take 459 characters making them the most comfortable phones for typing long messages.

The 33xx series also has soft keys and good button placement, which reduces fatigue. The Siemens A50 supports a whopping, 760 characters though, the keys are bit hard and therefore not really conducive to typing that much on the go.



Siemens A50
Rating: C-
Price: Rs 6,150



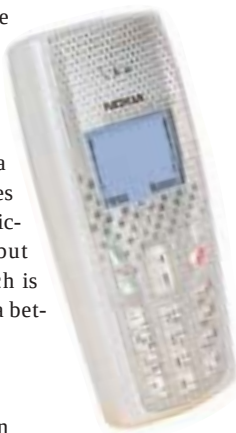
Nokia 3310
Rating: B
Price: Rs 5,495

Ring tones

None of the phones, including the Nokia 3610 and Sony Ericsson T200, had Polyphonic ring tones. However the Nokia 3310 had as many as 37 in-built ring tones and seven user-defined tones, either via downloading or composing—44 is enough of a variety by any standard. Many phones also had the feature of assigning specific ring tones to particular contacts—two models, namely the Motorola C300 and the Nokia 3610 did not have this feature. With the Nokia 3610 however, the user can assign different tones as SMS alerts.

PIM

Personal Information Managers (PIMs) are very important if you need to maintain an extensive number of notes and require an alarm and calendar to remember multiple things. Some high-end phones now support the ability to create and forward notes, to other supported devices. Sadly, these technologies are still expensive to integrate in the low-end phones, and therefore only a few, such as the Sony Ericsson T200, T100 and the Motorola C300 had them. The Sony Ericsson T200 and T100 are the only phones to give a weekly view of the calendar as well, which is very important if you need to key in notes for a particular date. All the Nokia phones had the reminder feature. The Sony Ericsson T200 is a good recommendation but it has very hard and noisy keys, which is not the case with the T100, making it a better choice over the T200.



Nokia 3610
Rating: B-
Price: Rs 7,499

Internet connectivity

WAP is outdated now, with GPRS looming on the horizon. The reason GPRS isn't already popular, is the poor network coverage by service providers and the high associated costs. Greater WAP content should be available once WAP over GPRS is made available in the market. With possible data

transfer rates of 171 Kbps, in theory, you will be able to browse, chat, send pictures, check e-mail and even transfer files. The advantages are many but the infrastructure is not yet ready. This is probably why only the Sony

Top 5	Talk time (in minutes)	
	Alcatel OT 311	330
	Motorola C300	300
	Seimens A50	300
	Sony Ericsson T200	300
	Nokia 3350	285

LG CDMA Phone

The LG CDMA phone is a part of the RelianceIndia mobile service. It is very compact and sturdy with a very firm grip. The keys are nicely laid out for easy browsing through the menus. There are four hotkeys for one-click access to the message menu, ring tones, R-world and phone book. R-World has two games, the R-menu and Multimedia tab, which did not work at the time of testing. Just like the Nokia phones, the reception was excellent—so loud at full network strength that the handset needed to be kept at a distance of at least an inch away from the ear. The reception quality drops significantly once the signal strength falls below the 50 per cent level.

The menu browsing is as easy as Sony Ericsson phones and you will not take more than 10 to 15 minutes to get used to the menu structure. Voice-dialling, a common feature, is absent from this phone—a major shortcoming. The phone also supports two phone lines, which is good feature for those who expect to get multiple calls simultaneously.

The four-way button works as the selector for four different

functions. This reduces the number of clicks required to perform simple tasks. The same ease is built in the planner where the user can easily key in the schedule and set an alarm as a reminder. The keys of the phone are a bit hard and therefore the users will find it a bit difficult to key in long messages and schedules. The four lines of messages lets the user read the SMS without much scrolling.

This phone is filled with all the regular features of the sub-Rs 8,000 category phones plus some more features such as the JAVA based games, *Mobile Hawk* and *Black Jack*. The phone has good voice clarity and ease of use.

